

Episode 82: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative! *Casshern Sins* Colour Design Notes (Part 3)

The **WBC** (*World Baseball Classic*) is **really exciting**! I'm also a huge baseball fan, so I can't help but be tremendously concerned about how the games turn out. Sports really should be enjoyed via live broadcast. Just knowing the results afterward is somehow unbearable for me.

But unfortunately, the preliminary game times coincided with travel between studios, or working in environments without TV or radio. Meetings can't be helped, but during travel and such, couldn't something be done? Following game progress on mobile phone news sites is also not quite right...

So I deployed it! A transistor radio!

I put a tiny AM radio in my pocket and listened to broadcasts through earphones while travelling. Well, this was quite something! I'm totally in love with radio now.

But visually, I definitely give off that unmistakable old guy vibe... (laughs).

Oh yes, I tried watching the TV broadcast on one-seg while listening to audio on radio, but one-seg arrives with incredible delay, doesn't it? Like, one play behind, one pitch behind.

"I see! People listening to radio are getting 'early access' compared to those watching on one-seg!"

I feel a bit superior somehow (laughs).

Now then.

Before entering the second half, today I'll delve into the mysteries of the opening and two endings.

First, the ending stories.

Ending 1 (Song: KANA "reason")

Storyboard & Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Key Animation: Okuda Yoshiko / Art: Kajiyama Nariyo / Colour Design & Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

Ending 2 (Song: Kuno Shinji "Light and Shadow")

Storyboard & Direction: Nakayama Naomi / Key Animation: Tominaga Mari / Art: Gyoshin Mitsu / Colour Design & Direction: Akimoto Yuki

I had heard from early on that the ending songs would change between first and second halves, so I decided from the beginning to have Kohinata-san and Akimoto-san, the two main colour direction staff, each handle everything for their respective endings.

So basically I was hands-off on the endings. I had them each meet with their respective directors and proceed however they wanted. I just waited excitedly for the finished products (laughs). So I don't have much to say about the endings from my perspective.

We originally planned for 12 episodes each for broadcast, but due to certain promotional relationships and main episode circumstances, the second one ended up with fewer broadcasts.

In the first ending, the "glass pendant" appears. That's the one Ringo gave to Lyuze in the main episode. I hadn't thought deeply about it, but the main episode with the pendant ended up being Kohinata-san's assigned episode by good coincidence (laughs).

In the second ending, Friender isn't on screen. So I asked director Nakayama-san:

"Hey, where's Friender?"

"Ah! (heavy sweat)"

"...C-can I interpret this as an ending from Friender's perspective?"

"...Y-yes. That's right!"

...Apparently that's what it is.

And now, the opening story.

Opening (Song: Colour Bottle "Blue Flower")

Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Key Animation: Umakoshi Yoshihiko /
Art: Kono Rei / Colour Direction & Colouring: Kunioto Kunio

"Right, we need to make an opening," said the director. Late summer last year, when the broadcast start was becoming somewhat visible. But after that, I hadn't really pursued the opening topic much. Because I myself was too busy with the final push for Jump Tours' *Dragon Ball Z* and the theatrical *New Saviour Legend Fist of the North Star: Kenshiro's Story*, so I was trying not to touch on that topic (laughs).

Then one evening, a call from production: "We're having an opening meeting."

Due to the art staff's schedule, the meeting was set for 1 AM. I was pretty exhausted, but I chugged coffee and attended the meeting.

"Basically, I want to show everyone as still images."

The idea was that since the main episodes moved incredibly densely, the opening should be solidly composed of accumulated still images. Of course, the animation would be by Umakoshi Yoshihiko. We'd mix in some cuts with movement as accents, but basically everything would be single drawings of Umakoshi's bold-lined animation.

"The problem is finding a method that properly utilises these animation lines,"- said the director.

"Ah..."-I said.

"Can't we make it like a poster?"

I think the greatest charm of Umakoshi's animation is the "rough feel" of those lines. I love the power of the lines he draws, and when he draws posters or stills, I try to utilise the "rough feel" of the lines, their textured quality.

You know, in old animation made with cels, the roughness of pencil lines would appear directly on the cels through carbon tracing, right? I wanted to somehow achieve that atmosphere, so I would deliberately roughly binarize the line art and reproduce somewhat rough, coarse, violent-feeling lines without too much line correction.

So, well, ultimately I ended up painting everything myself (laughs).

"For the moving parts, it doesn't need to be so precise."

Since my workload looked a bit tough, we had the finishing company handle colouring orders for cuts with movement, but I would paint everything else.

The meeting with the art staff centered on the colour direction for each cut. Like "up to this cut, make it bluish. From the next one, BAM! BAM! BAM! to orange." The background drawing style referenced the main episode art boards to some extent, then the director said "I leave the rest to you (laughs)."

So from the next day, I was doing colouring work all night long.

While the size was small, it was like painting licenced stills in a way, and since I'm not really doing heavy colouring work normally, my hands are slow (laughs).

There's specialised software called PaintMan for digital colouring, and normally everyone does main episode colouring with PaintMan, but I can't quite master PaintMan (laughs). So I painted using Photoshop. I always use Photoshop for posters and magazine stills.

And the battle with lines. Painting each section divided by rough lines properly would be incredibly difficult and deadly (laughs), so I separated the line parts into layers and placed them overlaid on top, saving that, then used the "eraser" tool on the original drawing underneath to boldly erase and paint over the lines themselves. This way I could paint quickly instead of fussily, and the lines themselves were saved in layers so it was fine. After finishing painting, I'd merge with the line layer above to complete it.

The flow of cut colours is more important in openings than in main episodes. Based on the colour flow decided in the meeting, I decided colours cut by cut, matching the musical tone and the art style. For example, riding the song's crescendo, gradually making colours stronger in a building fashion, or gently changing colours through overlap within a single cut.

That's how the opening was made. Unfortunately there wasn't enough time, so for the first several episodes the title cut "blue flower" ended up as a still image, but otherwise maybe I just fine-tuned the eye cut colours?

Such was the opening. I've done openings for various works, but this *Casshern Sins* opening is quite a favourite of mine.

